



Table tennis star Manika Batra, former India hockey captain Rani Rampal and chess player Tania Sachdev, receive the Award of Excellence from chess great Viswanathan Anand (right) and R. Doraiswamy, MD & CEO — LIC. EMMANUAL YOGINI

Influential stars

Indian chess stalwart Tania Sachdev, table tennis star Manika Batra, and former India women's hockey captain Rani Rampal were honoured with the Award of Excellence at the Sportstar Aces Awards 2026 in Mumbai, recognising their enduring influence on Indian sport across three different disciplines.

Chess great and Sportstar jury member Viswanathan Anand and R. Doraisamy, Managing Director and CEO of Life Insurance Corporation of India, presented the awards.

For more than a decade and a half, Tania has been one of the most recognisable faces of Indian women's chess. A Women's Grandmaster and FIDE International Master, she has represented India at numerous

international competitions and won the Commonwealth Women's Chess Championship three times. She was also part of the Indian women's team that created history by winning gold at the 45th FIDE Chess Olympiad.

Reflecting on the craft behind the sport, Tania spoke about the unseen labour that underpins success.

"Planning an endgame move against a seasoned player or explaining chess to an amateur both have their challenges. At different points in our lives, different things become challenging.

When I was playing competitive chess until the 2024 Olympiad, I would say preparation as an athlete is the hardest part. That is the least glamorous phase because no one is watching you. But that preparation

becomes the stepping stone to success."

Tania's influence has extended well beyond the chessboard. As a presenter and commentator, she has helped bring the intricacies of the game to a wider audience.

"Speaking of broadcasting, it is my second innings with the game. I feel privileged to call it my job now. And I definitely sleep better," she said with a laugh.

Manika, meanwhile, has become one of the most prominent ambassadors of Indian table tennis on the global stage. At the 2024 Summer Olympics, she became the first Indian table tennis player to reach the round of 16 in the singles event, defeating France's Prithika Pavade 4-0. Four years earlier, at the